

SAMPLE REPORT / EN

Emma's next move

Where your strengths, values and the market meet, and the routes that follow from it.

cairn /kɛərn/ noun

a mound of rough stones used to mark a trail, route, or summit, guiding travelers by showing the way forward, especially where the path isn't otherwise clear.

What's inside

ABOUT YOU

 **Executive Summary**

 **Your Approach**

 **Your Strengths**

 **Development Areas**

 **Career Values**

CAREER SUGGESTIONS FOR YOU

1 Primary Career Match
Service Designer · Large agency / consultancy (201-1000)

2 Second Career Match
Employee Experience Consultant · Large agency / consultancy (201-1000)

3 Third Career Match
Design Sprint Facilitator · Own company / boutique practice

 **Runner-up Careers**
3 alternatives

 **Outside the Box**
3 unconventional paths

 **Dream Job Assessment**
2 dream jobs

CHAPTER ONE

About you

Your working profile: how you operate, what you are good at, where the friction is, and what you actually value. Everything in the second half is built on this.

FROM YOUR REPORT

“ You operate as a builder who prefers structure with room to improvise.

Executive Summary

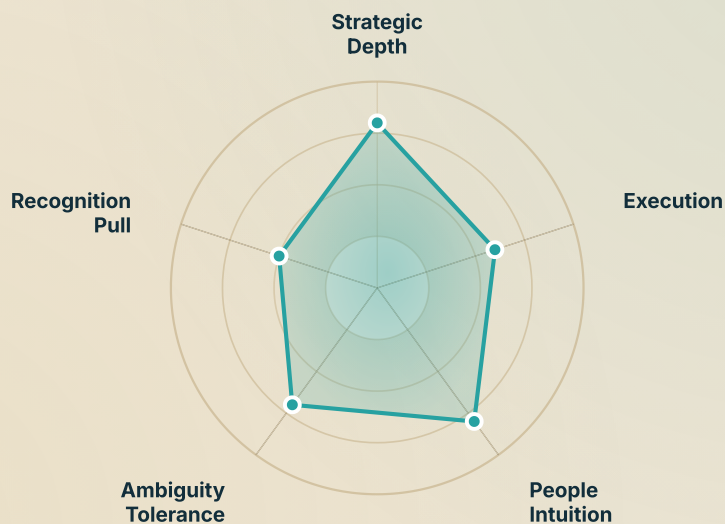
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PERSONALITY RADAR

5 axes

How you actually work

Your operating profile across five dimensions, built from the assessment and pressure-tested by your coach.



For further details regarding this graph, consult your [dashboard](#).

 OVERVIEW

Executive Summary



The short version of everything that follows: what your profile points to, which roles came out on top, and the first move worth making.

Professional Identity

You operate as a builder who prefers structure with room to improvise. Your approach favors clear ownership over consensus-by-committee, and you gravitate toward roles where you can see a direct line between your effort and a tangible outcome. What drives you isn't recognition for its own sake but the satisfaction of solving a problem that actually needed solving.

Key Strengths & Growth Areas

Your standout capability is translating ambiguous problems into workable plans, paired with a communication style that keeps teams aligned without over-managing them. Where you have room to grow is in delegation: you tend to hold onto details longer than necessary, which can slow you down as scope increases. You pushed back on the idea that you're conflict-avoidant, and that's fair to note here: your feedback suggests it's more selective engagement than avoidance, you choose your battles rather than duck them.

Career Direction

Your top match is **Product Manager**, which lines up with your comfort synthesizing input from multiple directions and making calls under incomplete information. **Operations Manager** follows closely, drawing on your systems thinking and bias toward efficiency. **Technical Program Manager** shows up as a strong runner-up given your hybrid interest in both people and technical detail. You were notably unenthusiastic about roles emphasizing pure individual contribution with minimal cross-team interaction, which tracks: your energy consistently shows up around coordination and shared outcomes, not solo execution.

Path Forward

The near-term priority is building a track record of scoped ownership, whether that's a project, a small team, or a product area, so the delegation muscle gets tested in real conditions. Look for roles that explicitly reward judgment over process-following, since that's where your profile has the most leverage. You've got the raw material for a strong management trajectory; the honest work now is proving it at increasing scale rather than searching for more assessments to confirm it.

ABOUT YOU

Understanding Your Approach



How you navigate challenges, lead teams and engage with the people around you, and what that means for the environments where you do your best work.

Personality and Interaction Style

Emma, you gravitate toward rooms where ideas get tested out loud: workshops, strategy decks, customer interviews. But your conflict style splits down the middle. With peers you say you address disagreements directly, yet your instinct in negotiation is to concede for harmony. That's not indecision, it's a hierarchy: you'll push hard on ideas but soften fast on relationships, which explains why you're the one people bring a messy deck to and trust it back.

Impact in Different Environments

The pattern pays off wherever the work is generative and social: your agency years, your happiest by far, were built on new problems every few weeks and rooms you could read and move. It costs you in environments built around defending numbers rather than shaping direction, which is exactly what's eroding your current role.

Key Insight

Your happiness scores rise and fall with proximity to the story, not with title or budget size. The fintech job gave you the broadest scope of your career and your second-lowest score, because scope without storytelling authority isn't the thing you actually want.

ABOUT YOU

Strengths and How to Grow Them



What sets you apart professionally, and how to put more weight on it.

Identifying Your Core Strengths

Emma, underneath your skills list sits one core capability: you find the sentence that makes a messy situation legible to other people, whether that is a product direction, a cross-team dilemma, or an organizational decision. The repositioning work, the insight programme the product team leans on, and the peers who seek you out before critical decisions all stem from that same diagnostic instinct. You catch misalignments before they are smoothed over.

Leveraging Strengths in Your Career

This is diagnostic and advisory work, even when packaged inside a marketing title. Given your pull toward impact and away from spreadsheet-heavy execution, you can direct this sense-making toward broader organizational questions—such as change consulting, founder advisory, or cross-functional

strategy. Focus on framing your contributions around the structural misalignments you surfaced and the working models teams adopted as a result.

Key Insight

While your titles have often emphasized campaign execution, your enduring value rests in translation: turning what people do into a clear direction an organization can rally around. That diagnostic noticing depends entirely on presence, social trust, and judgment about people, making it resilient against automation and far more expansive than any single functional remit.

ABOUT YOU

Areas for Development



The areas where focused effort makes the biggest difference to the goals you named. Not weaknesses, but the things currently costing you the most.

Understanding Potential Growth Areas

Perfectionism, self-criticism, and over-owning responsibility feed directly into each other: Emma, you set an exacting bar, carry the burden alone, and doubt yourself when the result feels imperfect. In practice, this emerges as an internal calibration challenge. Your finish line is calibrated to an exceptionally high standard, prompting you to ship work early and then continuously polish post-release because your internal meter rarely registers a project as completely finished.

Implications for Your Growth

When exploring a meaningful pivot, this ongoing cycle risks stalling your momentum. Because you rarely decide independently that a deliverable is finished, an external standard offers the most reliable anchor. Swapping out an internal gauge for concrete external checkpoints keeps your progress steady. Roles and environments featuring structured review points and agreed-upon milestones suit you especially well, giving you clear, objective markers of completion instead of leaving you in self-certifying ambiguity.

Key Insight

Your response to critique connects directly to that high internal standard. You absorb feedback deeply, occasionally internalizing tactical notes as sweeping evaluations of your overall competence. Grounding critiques within their specific, tactical boundaries keeps revisions productive while protecting your energy.

Your reflection on AI eroding your distinct craft points to an essential truth: as automated tools handle baseline execution, your intuitive judgment about people and what genuinely resonates with them remains your strongest, least replicable asset.

♥ ABOUT YOU

Aligning with Your Values



What matters most to you in your work, and how that shapes which roles will actually fit rather than merely look good.

🕒 Identifying Your Core Values

Impact outranks growth, and growth outranks autonomy, which is a specific order: you want to matter to something before you want independence in how you get there. That tracks with your dream of running a research studio for organisations, but it sits oddly next to your best year, the agency, which offered you autonomy and challenge with the thinnest cause attached of any job you've held.

🗨️ Values in Career Decisions

Any next role needs a visible line from your work to a person or outcome you can name, plus room to run the sense-making yourself rather than defend it in dashboards. It needs to exclude data-heavy, spreadsheet-first work and solo, low-contact tasks, both of which you've flagged directly as drains.

💡 Key Insight

You rank impact highest, yet your happiest year ran on craft and momentum with little cause behind it at all. That tension suggests "impact" for you may mean the felt sense of changing how people understand something, not a mission statement, which opens more doors than a strict cause-driven search would.

CHAPTER TWO

Career recommendations

Roles matched against the profile in chapter one. Your top three first, then close alternatives, then the unexpected directions and a reality check on your dream job.

FROM YOUR REPORT

“ The agency structure (project pods, peer support) also protects against what's currently draining you at 5/10, the dashboard and re-forecasting grind that keeps pulling you away from positioning and storytelling.

Service Designer

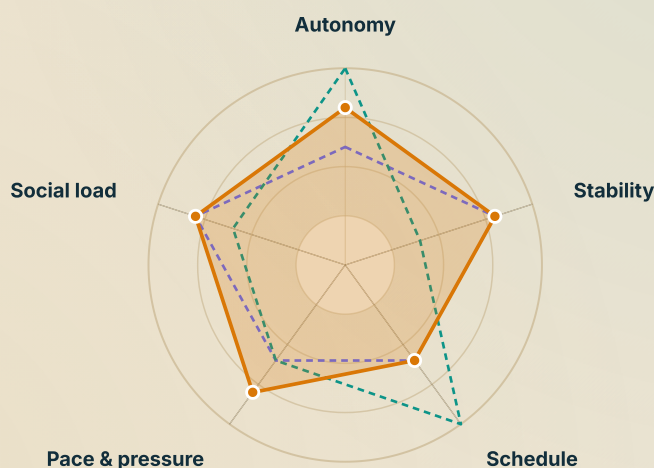
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TOP THREE COMPARED

How your top three stack up

The same three roles measured against the working conditions you said matter most.

- 1. Service Designer
- - 2. Employee Experience Consultant
- - - 3. Design Sprint Facilitator



For further details regarding this graph, consult your [dashboard](#).

🏆 TOP MATCH · 01



Your strongest match, based on your personality, values and skills. What the work involves, why it fits, and what to be honest with yourself about.

Service Designer

Large agency / consultancy (201-1000)

🎯 MATCH · 90%

🛠️ AI · MODERATE

📈 UPSKILL

👁️ Overview

A service designer researches how people actually experience an organization (front and back stage), then redesigns the systems and touchpoints behind that experience so it works better for everyone involved.

🧩 Why this role fits you

Helping others and making an impact sits at the top of what drives you, and this role turns that into a daily practice: you're not writing a mission statement, you're sitting with 30+ people a year to find out what's actually broken in how an organization treats them, then fixing it. That's the same instinct that made your customer-insight programme something the product team leans on more than marketing does.

This role extends your 8/10 Brand Strategist pattern almost exactly: a new client problem every few weeks, a workshop, a deck that makes a room go quiet. The agency structure (project pods, peer support) also protects against what's currently draining you at 5/10, the dashboard and re-forecasting grind that keeps pulling you away from positioning and storytelling. Your perfectionist streak gets useful external checkpoints here instead of spiraling.

☰ What you'll actually do

- Run discovery research. Conduct contextual inquiries and stakeholder interviews, the same muscle you built doing 30+ customer interviews a year.
- Build service blueprints. Turn messy, chaotic input into a visual map a whole company can rally around, exactly what you did with your outcome-led repositioning work.
- Facilitate co-creation workshops. Your AJ&Smart sprint training and room-reading instincts get used weekly, not occasionally.
- Present to leadership. Translate research into a narrative that moves skeptical stakeholders, drawing on your storytelling craft.

⚠️ The Reality Check

- ⚠️ Conservative clients slow the work down. Convincing corporate stakeholders to embrace organizational change (not just a new campaign) takes more patience than agency brand work did, and your harmony-seeking conflict style could mean conceding ground too early.

⚠️ Blueprinting is a genuine skill gap. You have the research and facilitation down cold, but formal service blueprinting and target operating model artifacts are new territory. Realistic path: shadow 2-3 live projects and take a short service design certification (e.g. from a recognized service design school), roughly 2-3 months to get fluent, not years.

⚠️ Proposal crunches will test your flexibility rule. Client pitch deadlines surge unpredictably. With a partner on nursing shifts, you'll need to negotiate which weeks you protect early with your team.

The practical stuff

Money: £50,000-£75,000. This sits at or slightly below your £50k-75k bracket midpoint, comfortably within target, though senior consulting rates in London agencies often flex upward once you're placed.

Schedule: Standard agency hours with surges during discovery sprints and pitches. Your flexible-hours requirement is workable here since agencies increasingly support hybrid, but sprint weeks will test it occasionally.

Energy: High client and colleague interaction, daily, inside small project pods. This matches your "somewhat energized, but I have a limit" profile precisely because pods (not open-floor exposure) contain the interaction.

Growth: Leads to Lead Service Designer, then Design Director or Strategic Design Partner, a real ladder toward running research-driven change work.

How AI will impact this role

Moderate. AI now handles qualitative coding, persona synthesis, and first-pass blueprint visuals, the grunt work that currently eats your week. Strategic stakeholder alignment and ethnographic empathy, your actual edge, stay human. Given your "moderately familiar" AI comfort, this role hands you a natural on-ramp rather than a steep climb.

Future-proof skills

- Own the synthesis layer: Get fluent directing AI tools for interview coding so you spend saved hours on judgment calls, not data cleanup.
- Build workshop-facilitation depth: Deepen live, high-stakes facilitation skill (skeptical execs, dominant voices), the part no AI tool touches.

Alignment with your ambitions

Your short-term goal is new skills in a different setting, and this delivers formal service design methodology on top of what you already do well. Your long-term ambition, contributing to a cause and running your own research studio, makes this less a detour and more a credentialing platform: 2-3 years here builds the blueprinting and org-design chops that make your own studio (your stated dream job) more fundable later.

🏆 TOP MATCH · 02



Your second match. Close to the first in overall fit, but different in focus, environment or trajectory.

Employee Experience Consultant

Large agency / consultancy (201-1000)

🎯 MATCH · 84%

🏠 AI · HIGH

📈 UPSKILL

👁 Overview

An employee experience consultant researches how staff actually feel about their workplace, then designs journey maps and interventions to fix culture, tools, and processes that aren't working.

🧩 Why this role fits you

Your happiest professional years weren't about the industry, they were about the shape of the work: a new problem every few weeks, a workshop, a deck that made a room go quiet. This role extends your 8/10 Brand Strategist pattern by keeping that exact rhythm and swapping the subject from customers to employees, which plays directly into your top value of helping others and making an impact.

It's the same diagnostic instinct you've already proven, sitting in customer interviews to spot which story a company tells itself, just pointed inward at organizations instead of outward at markets. The structured consulting milestones and pod-based teams also guard against the isolating grind currently deflating you at 5/10 in your fintech role, where dashboards have crowded out the storytelling work you're actually good at.

☰ What you'll actually do

- Run sentiment audits. Conduct qualitative focus groups on workplace culture, a direct extension of your customer-interview synthesis skill.
- Map employee journeys. Build journey maps and interventions using the same synthesis method that shortened your last product's sales cycle by 20%.
- Present roadmaps to CHROs. Your stakeholder management and storytelling craft carry the strategic narrative into the boardroom.
- Facilitate steering committee workshops. Use your workshop facilitation training to build consensus among competing executive priorities.

⚠ The Reality Check

- ⚠ Client politics move slowly. Executives resistant to progressive culture change will stall projects for months, and your instinct to over-own client outcomes (a known tendency for you) makes that slowness personally frustrating rather than just a process fact.
- ⚠ Scope creep is structural. Multi-stakeholder enterprise projects invite constant "can you also look at..." requests. Protecting boundaries here matters more than in agency brand work, where scope was tighter.

⚠ Domain shift is light but real. Your journey-mapping skill transfers almost directly, but you'll need context adaptation, HR tech familiarity (Workday, Culture Amp) and organizational psychology framing. Realistic path: one short course plus your first live project, about 6-8 weeks to feel fluent, since your interview and synthesis skills already do the heavy lifting.

📦 The practical stuff

Money: £52,000-£80,000. This lands squarely inside your £50k-75k bracket, and the top end exceeds it, so this hits your target without a pay cut.

Schedule: Standard consulting hours with predictable milestone peaks. More predictable than agency pitch cycles, which works better against your flexible-hours requirement.

Energy: High daily interaction with client HR leaders and multidisciplinary pods. Sits within your "somewhat energized, with a limit" range because the pod structure distributes the social load.

Growth: Leads toward Practice Lead for Employee Experience, or eventually an in-house Chief People Officer track, a genuine leadership runway.

🤖 How AI will impact this role

Substantial, per the enriched data, though the human core (reading organizational politics, building executive trust) resists automation. AI increasingly handles sentiment data crunching and first-draft journey maps; your job shifts toward interpreting what the data actually means for a resistant executive team. Your moderate AI familiarity means you'll want hands-on time with sentiment analytics tools early, not later.

🛡 Future-proof skills

- **Learn HR analytics tools:** Get working fluency in Culture Amp or Workday reporting so you direct the data instead of waiting on analysts.
- **Sharpen executive influence:** Build a repeatable framework for landing "non-intuitive" recommendations with skeptical CHROs, your real differentiator as AI handles more analysis.

🎯 Alignment with your ambitions

This fits your short-term goal of developing new skills in a different setting, applying your marketing toolkit to organizational psychology. Against your long-term ambition of significant societal contribution and running your own research studio, this is a genuine bridge (not a detour): it builds people-focused consulting credibility that translates directly if you eventually go independent.

🏆 TOP MATCH · 03



Your third match, and the last of the top three. Worth reading even if the first two landed better, since it often isolates what you actually want.

Design Sprint Facilitator

Own company / boutique practice

🕒 MATCH · 84%

🏠 AI · HIGH

🚀 READY NOW

👁 Overview

A design sprint facilitator runs intensive multi-day workshops where cross-functional teams solve a specific business problem and test a prototype, compressed into days instead of months.

☰ What you'll actually do

- Facilitate live sprints. Run multi-day workshops using your AJ&Smart certification, the credential you already hold and haven't fully monetized.
- Design workshop agendas. Build digital boards and structure exercises that channel your love of "a strategy deck that made a room go quiet."
- Recruit test participants. Line up user testing sessions, using the interview-scheduling instincts from your 30+ interviews-a-year research programme.
- Manage your own pipeline. Pitch, propose, and scope follow-on work directly with client leadership, no account team buffer.

You've already said this kind of work lets you learn new skills and push into new territory, which lines up with your stated interest in developing strategic planning and creative innovation capability, but here you'd be the one setting the curriculum, not attending someone else's workshop.

🧩 Why this role fits you

This role isolates the exact ingredient that made your Brand Strategist years your best: the room, the live problem-solving, the tangible outcome by Friday. It extends your 8/10 Brand Strategist pattern more directly than any other option, stripping away the account management and client retainer overhead and leaving just the facilitation itself, the part you're certified in and clearly energized by.

It also answers your autonomy value directly. As a solo practitioner you control your calendar, which matters given your partner's nursing shifts and your non-negotiable need for flexible hours. Sprint-based work means intense delivery weeks followed by open prep weeks, a rhythm few employee roles can offer.

⚠ The Reality Check

- ⚠ Client acquisition never stops. As a solo facilitator, you are the pipeline. There's no account team booking your calendar, every quiet week is your job to fill, and your discomfort with self-promotion (not previously tested in your career) will get real pressure here.

⚠ Live sprint days are physically demanding. Multi-day facilitation with dominant, skeptical executives requires sustained high energy and room control. Your harmony-seeking conflict style needs deliberate override in these rooms, conceding to the loudest voice derails a sprint.

⚠ Income has no floor early on. Boutique practice means variable, lumpy engagements while you build a reputation and referral network, distinct from the steady consulting cadence of an agency role.

The practical stuff

Money: Day rates typically £800-£1,800 depending on client size, translating to an annual range of roughly £48,000-£90,000 at moderate utilization. This can exceed your £50k-75k bracket in strong years, but expect the first 6-12 months to run below it while you build a client base, income variability is real and needs a cash buffer given your London mortgage.

Schedule: High-intensity delivery weeks alternating with flexible prep and business-development weeks. This is the closest match to your non-negotiable flexible-hours requirement of any option here.

Energy: High-intensity social bursts during sprints, then low-contact solo weeks. This actually suits your "somewhat energized, with a limit" profile well, since the limit gets a built-in recovery week rather than daily depletion.

Growth: Can scale into a small facilitation agency with a roster of contractors, or pivot into fractional Head of Product Innovation work.

How AI will impact this role

Substantial. AI increasingly handles workshop prep logistics, agenda templates, and synthesis write-ups after the sprint. The live facilitation itself, reading a room, managing dominant personalities, keeping momentum, stays entirely human and becomes your clearer differentiator as routine prep work gets automated.

Future-proof skills

- Automate your admin: Use AI for agenda drafts, participant recruitment emails, and post-sprint synthesis docs, freeing more hours for billable facilitation.
- Build a facilitator brand: Publish opinionated takes on sprint methodology to compress your client acquisition cycle, since referrals alone won't fill a solo calendar fast enough.

Alignment with your ambitions

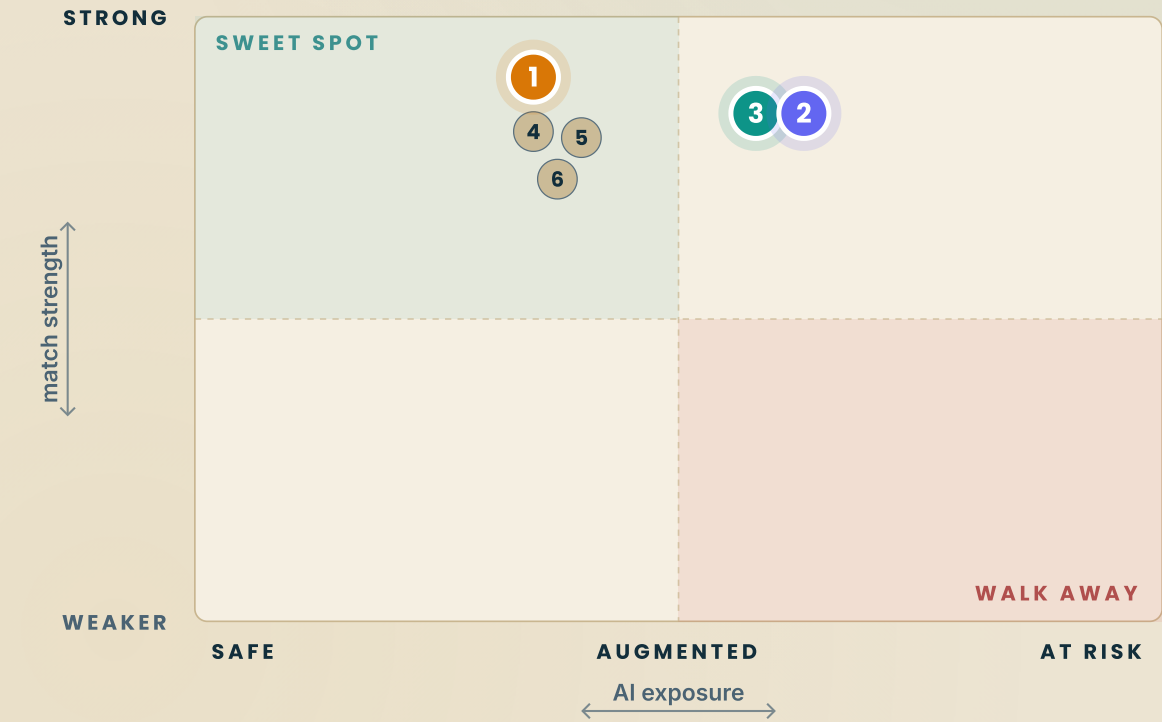
This satisfies your short-term goal of building new skills (business development, solo practice management) you haven't needed before. But your long-term ambition centers on significant societal contribution and possibly running a research studio, and pure sprint facilitation is narrower than that vision. At 38 with a mortgage, treat this as a viable path in its own right or a proving ground for solo consulting, not automatically a stepping stone to your dream job.

CAREER MAP

Where the matches sit

Your roles plotted by match strength against AI-exposure risk. Sweet spot is top-left; bottom-right is the walk-away zone.

- 1 Service Designer
- 2 Employee Experience Consultant
- 3 Design Sprint Facilitator
- 4 Behavioural Communications Consultant
- 5 Customer Experience (CX) Strategist
- 6 Founder, Qualitative Research Studio



For further details regarding this graph, consult your [dashboard](#).

🏆 RUNNER-UP CAREERS · 3 ROLES



Close alternatives to your top three. Also strong fits for your strengths and values, but differing in focus, work environment or trajectory. A comparison set rather than the creative picks.

Behavioural Communications Consultant

Large (201-1000) / Agency / Consultancy

🔄 MATCH · 81%

🤖 AI · MODERATE

📈 UPSKILL

👁 Overview

You'd apply psychology and "nudge" theory to help clients craft communications that actually change behaviour, mixing research, workshops, and campaign strategy for a range of client accounts.

🧩 Why this role fits you

Your specialised knowledge of "how people actually make buying decisions" is basically behavioural science by another name, so this is a near-literal translation of what you already do. It didn't crack Top 3 because it represents a lateral career pivot into a formal discipline focused on campaign-level psychology, meaning more relearning than your other options.

👍 What works for you

- 👉 **Plays to your gift.** Your talent for spotting the story a company tells itself maps directly onto behavioural diagnosis. 📌 **Team-based, not solo.** High colleague interaction with creatives and analysts suits your small-team preference. 📌 **Intellectually fresh.** New frameworks (COM-B, EAST) satisfy your growth and novelty appetite.

⚠ The Reality Check

- ⚠ **Reskilling required.** You'd need formal grounding in behavioural frameworks — a certification (6-12 months part-time) rather than a full degree, and AI-assisted learning can speed this up. 📌 **Starts you at consultant level.** Entering a new discipline at 38 with 15 years elsewhere may mean a lateral title, not a leadership one, initially. 📌 **Client skepticism is real.** You'd spend energy convincing traditional creative teams to trust counter-intuitive recommendations — a genuine friction point given your natural preference for harmony over ongoing debate.

📁 The practical stuff

Money: £52,000 - £80,000 (London)

Schedule: Standard agency hours, surges around pitches

Energy: High client and colleague interaction

🤖 How AI will impact this role

Moderate — AI speeds up research synthesis and message testing; your strategic framing and ethical judgment stay central. Fits your "moderately familiar" AI comfort well.

🛡️ Future-proof skills

- **Behavioural framework fluency:** Get certified in COM-B or EAST within a year to legitimise your existing intuition.
- **AI-assisted testing:** Use AI tools to run message experiments faster, freeing you for framing and client advisory.

Customer Experience (CX) Strategist

Own Company / Boutique

🔄 MATCH · 80%

🏠 AI · MODERATE

🔄 REFRAME

Based on your feedback, Product Marketing Consultant was set aside because it felt like your current job with invoicing attached, offering no meaningful change. Instead, we suggest Customer Experience (CX) Strategist — a direction that applies your customer-insight strengths to reshaping end-to-end user journeys rather than marketing outputs.

👁️ Overview

You'd guide organisations to redesign their end-to-end customer journeys by translating qualitative discovery, user motivations, and behavioural touchpoints into tangible service improvements.

🧩 Why this role fits you

This builds directly on the qualitative insight programme you created that internal teams already trust, letting you stay anchored in genuine customer understanding. It sits as a runner-up because it involves navigating complex cross-departmental alignment across product, operations, and support, rather than focusing purely on strategic storytelling.

👍 What works for you

- 👉 **Anchored in qualitative empathy.** Centers on deep discovery and understanding how people actually experience a service, matching your 30+ interviews a year background. 📌 **Collaborative advisory role.** High interaction with diverse operational teams, fitting your preference for small teams and delegated trust. 📌 **Meaningful variety.** Diagnosing distinct journey friction points across multiple touchpoints provides intellectual novelty without solo freelance isolation.

⚠️ The Reality Check

- ⚠️ **Matrixed stakeholder navigation.** Driving journey changes requires influencing teams you do not directly manage, which can create tension for a harmony-seeking style. 📌 **Operational learning curve.** CX connects directly to operational systems and service delivery, requiring an understanding of back-stage processes alongside customer front-ends. 📌 **Attribution ambiguity.** Demonstrating the commercial return of customer satisfaction and friction reduction takes longer than direct marketing campaign metrics.

📦 The practical stuff

Money: £60,000 - £85,000 (London)

Schedule: Standard corporate or consultancy hours, occasional delivery sprints

Energy: High collaborative workshop facilitation and cross-functional advisory

How AI will impact this role

Moderate — AI accelerates journey analytics and customer feedback synthesis, but qualitative interpretation, empathy, and stakeholder orchestration remain distinctly human.

Future-proof skills

- **Journey mapping & service blueprinting:** Formalise your qualitative research into visual blueprints to give operational teams immediate clarity.
- **AI-augmented synthesis:** Use AI tools to cluster large volumes of feedback, preserving your energy for high-depth interviews and executive alignment.

Founder, Qualitative Research Studio

Own Company / Boutique

 **MATCH · 80%**

 **AI · MODERATE**

 **RETRAIN**

Overview

You'd build and run your own boutique consultancy doing deep ethnographic and qualitative research, helping organisations understand the people they serve, then turning that into strategy for clients.

Why this role fits you

This is your stated dream job, almost word for word, and it channels the customer-insight programme you built that product teams now trust more than marketing. It sits below Top 3 because founding a studio means real capital and income risk upfront, a heavier lift than a role that lets you plug in more immediately.

What works for you

- ☑ **Literally your dream job.** Running a research studio helping organisations understand their people is what you told us you want. 📌 **Total autonomy.** Complete control over methodology and client selection, matching your love of delegated trust. 📌 **Builds on proven strength.** Your 30+ interviews/year insight programme already proves you can do this at scale.

The Reality Check

- ⚠ **Capital and runway.** Founder path_type means unpredictable cash flow before profitability — plan for 12-18 months of variable income against your mortgage. 📌 **Validation is on you.** You'd need to prove studio viability through real client contracts, not assumptions, before it feels safe. 📌 **Business development never stops.** Constant pitching sits uneasily with your "avoid solo, sales-heavy work" instinct, even with a team.

The practical stuff

Money: £50,000 - £105,000 (variable, early years lower)

Schedule: Multi-year build, intense early phase

Energy: Very high client interaction, variable team size

How AI will impact this role

Moderate — AI handles transcription and coding, but your ethnographic depth and executive trust remain the studio's differentiator.

Future-proof skills

- **Founder-led sales:** Build pitching confidence deliberately, since this is the one skill standing between you and your dream job.
- **AI-augmented ops:** Use AI to run transcription and coding at scale so you and contractors focus purely on insight and client trust.

💡 OUTSIDE-THE-BOX CAREERS · 3 ROLES



Sometimes the best paths are not the obvious ones. These roles fit who you are but probably were not on your radar.

Museum Interpretation Manager

Medium (51-200) / Nonprofit

AI · MODERATE

REFRAME

👁 Overview

You'd shape how a museum or heritage site translates its collections and archives into narratives visitors actually connect with, working across curatorial, education, and visitor-experience teams. The job is equal parts audience research, script writing for exhibits and tours, and testing what lands with real people before it goes live.

🧩 Why this might be a fit

This pulls on the exact muscle your profile names as your real asset: making messy material legible to people, applied to objects and history instead of products. It's a genuine field change (heritage/culture, not corporate marketing) while still giving you workshops, stakeholder rooms, and visible storytelling authority, and it sits far from spreadsheets or pipeline defense.

Heads-up: heritage sector salaries often land at the lower end of your £50-75k range, especially outside national institutions.

🔗 Path Type & Reality

Employee role: expect a competitive but not brutal hiring process, usually via a formal application and portfolio/case-study interview rather than networked hustle.

🤖 AI Impact on this role

Moderate. AI can help draft label copy or synthesize visitor feedback, but deciding what story a collection tells and how to make it land emotionally with a live audience stays a human judgment call.

Athlete Wellbeing and Development Manager

Medium (51-200) / Nonprofit

 **AI · MINIMAL**

 **UPSKILL**

Overview

You'd support athletes (at a sports club, national governing body, or university programme) through career transitions, personal development, and life-outside-sport planning, working alongside coaches and performance staff. It's part programme design, part one-on-one guidance, part building the structures that don't naturally exist in performance-obsessed environments.

Why this might be a fit

Your long-distance hiking points to a genuine pull toward endurance and physical discipline, and your track record of building durable programmes (the customer-interview programme) plus your reflective, people-first listening style is unusually rare inside sports organisations, which tend to be heavy on performance data and light on human development structure. It's a real sector pivot away from marketing entirely, keeps you in rooms with people rather than dashboards, and lets your sense-making skill build something that outlasts you.

Heads-up: entry into this niche often starts below your target range, particularly outside elite/pro tier organisations.

Path Type & Reality

Employee role: hiring cycles run through sports organisations and universities, often requiring some relevant certification (e.g. career transition or coaching-adjacent credentials) to be taken seriously by a recruiter.

AI Impact on this role

Minimal to Moderate. This work depends on trust, presence, and reading a person in a vulnerable moment, which AI can support with resources but cannot replace.

Editorial Director, Podcast/Audio Documentary Studio

Startup / Media

 **AI · MODERATE**

 **UPSKILL**

Overview

You'd lead the editorial vision and narrative arc for a slate of nonfiction audio or documentary projects, working with producers and researchers to shape raw interview material into a story that holds an audience. This is a step toward, but genuinely distinct from, your named dream job: it's the editorial/leadership layer of documentary-adjacent work rather than the hands-on producer role itself.

Why this might be a fit

Your fifteen years of turning "what people do" into a story an organization can act on is precisely the skill an editorial director applies to raw interview tape instead of a brand brief. It moves you into a creative industry identity shift out of corporate marketing entirely, keeps you in a room with collaborators rather than working solo, and gives you narrative authority without requiring you to become a technical audio producer from scratch.

Heads-up: independent studios and mid-size production houses often pay below your target range at entry level; senior editorial roles at established studios can close the gap.

Path Type & Reality

Employee role at a small studio to start, with freelance editorial/story-consulting work as a realistic add-on once you've built a portfolio of credits.

AI Impact on this role

Moderate. AI speeds up transcription and rough-cut assembly, but shaping which parts of a person's story matter and why is the editorial judgment that keeps this role human-led.

✨ YOUR DREAM JOBS · 2 ROLES



You told us your dream job without worrying about constraints, and that was deliberate. Here we put the constraints back in: not to talk you out of it, but to show what getting there would really take, and what a version of it might look like that fits the experience you already have.

Documentary Producer

AI · MODERATE

RETRAIN

👁 Overview

Emma, this dream makes total sense on paper: it's the purest version of what you already do, turning what people say and do into a story that lands, minus the corporate wrapper. The catch is that "documentary producer" as an entry point looks nothing like your current seniority, pay, or stability, even though the underlying craft is identical.

🔄 Feasibility Rating

Low - Moderate: The craft fit is excellent, but the entry-level path (freelance, unpaid development, festival-circuit grind) would mean a steep income and status reset from where you sit today.

👤 Personality & Energy Fit

- Your "Somewhat Energized" social battery suits documentary work's collaborative shoots and edit-room debates, but the isolated, self-directed stretches of development and fundraising sit right in your stated avoidance zone (solo, research-heavy work).
- Your deadline-aware pace and preference for some process work against the unpredictable, often unstructured commissioning and funding cycles typical of documentary production.
- The novelty here is real fuel against your "Competence Trap", but the years of underpaid, precarious grind before any stability could easily tip your perfectionism into burnout rather than relief.

👑 The "Executive Version" Suggestion

- Rather than a hands-on Producer role, target Executive Producer or Series Editor at an established documentary or factual studio, someone who shapes narrative arc and greenlights stories rather than chasing funding reel by reel.
- This solves the low-salary, low-stimulus risk of ground-level production work: it uses your stakeholder management and story-synthesis skills at a strategic altitude, with a team around you instead of you doing every job at once.
- This exact version showed up in your Out of Box list as Editorial Director, Podcast/Audio Documentary Studio, which is a strong validation that this instinct is worth pursuing through that door rather than the traditional producer ladder.

📣 Industry Outlook & Regional Trends

- UK and Northern European factual/documentary roles at editorial or executive producer level typically land £45k-£70k at mid-size studios, with entry-level producer or researcher roles often starting well below £35k.
- AI Impact: Moderate. AI speeds up transcription, rough cuts, and archive search, but deciding which human story matters and how to shape it emotionally stays firmly a human judgment call.

- The UK has a genuinely strong indie documentary and streaming-commissioned factual sector, but it's competitive and heavily network-driven, meaning your existing stakeholder relationships matter more than a formal credential here.

🛡️ Future-proof skills

- Your ability to find "the one sentence that makes a messy thing make sense" is exactly the editorial judgment AI can't replicate, that's your differentiator in every pitch room.
- Build fluency in AI-assisted rough-cut and research tools now, so you can direct a leaner production team rather than be replaced by one.

🔗 Steps for Pursuing This Role

- Test the dream at low stakes: shadow or assist on a short documentary or branded-content film project through your existing agency or industry contacts before quitting anything.
- No gating credential exists for this field (no licence required), so your CIM Diploma and MA in Strategic Communication are relevant background, not a barrier; a short factual filmmaking or story-editing course would speed credibility, not gate entry.
- Build a portfolio career bridge: keep marketing consulting or freelance brand strategy work part-time while you build documentary credits, so the mortgage doesn't depend on festival acceptance.

Heads-up: entry-level documentary production income sits well below your £50k-£75k target; the Executive Producer / Series Editor path is the realistic way to close that gap.

Founder, Research Studio (Human-Centred Insight)

AI · MODERATE

REFRAME

👁️ Overview

This is the dream job that most directly matches your actual daily superpower, Emma: turning qualitative human research into a story an organisation can act on. Unlike documentary work, this one doesn't require you to leave your existing network, skills, or client base behind; it's a natural extension of what you already do inside your current job, just unbundled and run on your own terms.

📈 Feasibility Rating

Moderate - High: You already have the core skillset (30+ interviews a year, customer-insight programme built from scratch) and the credibility; what's missing is the business infrastructure of running your own shop, not the craft itself.

👤 Personality & Energy Fit

- Running a studio (even a small one) means client-facing collaboration and small-team structure, which fits your "Somewhat Energized" social profile and your stated need to avoid solo, isolated work far better than solo documentary filmmaking would.
- Your preference for delegated autonomy and comfort with risk align well with founder life, though your deadline-aware pacing means you'll need to build in structure since there's no external boss setting the clock.

- This path directly interrupts your Competence Trap: instead of doing the same job "with your eyes closed," you're rebuilding the skill from the ground up in a context that actually excites you, which is a real burnout antidote rather than just a change of scenery.

The "Executive Version" Suggestion

- The Executive Version of this dream is already the dream: Founder of a boutique qualitative research studio, positioned to serve mid-size B2B or fintech clients (your exact former world), commanding senior consulting rates rather than freelance researcher rates.
- This solves the low-income risk of solo freelance research by building a studio model (you plus a small associate network), letting you sell strategic insight engagements rather than billing hourly as a lone contractor.
- This appeared directly in your runner-up list as "Founder, Qualitative Research Studio" (rank 6, compatibility 80), which confirms the algorithm sees the same fit you feel; it's your named dream job validated independently.

Industry Outlook & Regional Trends

- Independent qualitative research/insight consultants in the UK and Netherlands/Germany typically bill £500-£900/day once established; a studio with 2-3 repeat clients can realistically clear £70k-£100k within 2-3 years.
- AI Impact: Moderate. AI can transcribe and summarise interviews fast, but clients pay for the synthesis, the "which story is this company telling itself" judgment call, which stays human and is actually your premium differentiator against cheaper AI-only research tools.
- Demand is real but the market is crowding with AI-assisted research tools promising faster insights; your edge is positioning as the strategic sense-maker, not a data collector, especially selling into fintech/scale-up clients you already understand.

Future-proof skills

- Your specialised knowledge of how people actually make decisions versus what they claim is a genuinely rare, hard-to-automate asset; lead with that as your studio's core positioning, not "research services" generically.
- Get fluent enough in AI transcription/synthesis tools to offer clients a faster, leaner engagement than traditional agencies, using AI as your junior analyst rather than your competitor.

Steps for Pursuing This Role

- Test this at low stakes now: offer one paid pilot research engagement to a former colleague's company or your own network while still employed, to validate demand and pricing.
- No gating credential blocks this field; your CIM Diploma, MA in Strategic Communication, and Design Sprint certification (AJ&Smart) already give you strong, credible positioning, so this is a go-to-market problem, not a retraining one.
- Bridge financially with a portfolio approach: keep one part-time consulting retainer (positioning/brand strategy, close to your current skill set) running while you build the studio's first 2-3 clients.

FROM YOUR CONVERSATION

Discussion Highlights



What came out of talking it through with your coach. These are the points where something shifted: a pattern you named, a correction you made, or a conclusion the two of you reached together. Your own words shaped the report you have just read.

- **Use diagnostic credits on your CV, not task lists.** Recast execution-heavy bullets into outcomes like “identified misalignment between sales and product on target customer, reframed positioning to resolve it, adopted as the working model,” and repeat that for 2-3 examples so your judgment reads as the product, not the email campaigns.
- **Anchor completion to external checkpoints.** Because you ship early and then keep polishing, the coach said your finish line needs to live outside you, through agreed milestones, structured review points, or someone else explicitly telling you it is good enough.
- **Name the “over-absorbing” critique pattern separately from defensiveness.** You do not push feedback away, you take one tactical note as a verdict on your whole competence, which is corrosive rather than protective and is costing you energy you do not need to spend.
- **Treat the Head of Marketing offer as more dashboards, not more storytelling authority.** The coach tied your 5/10 fintech score to “dashboards, attribution debates, and re-forecasting pipeline,” and said a bigger team and budget in the same structure likely means more of that, so the title is not a reason to say yes if the work is still the wrong axis.
- **Use a structural counter for your harmony-seeking tendency.** In roles like Service Designer, the coach warned you are more likely to fold too early under stakeholder pushback, so you should pre-agree a line you will not cross or bring a second voice into the room before the CFO-style compromise happens again.
- **Ask directly how pitch weeks are staffed before accepting any role with fixed early finishes.** For agency-based consulting, the coach said proposal crunches are genuinely unpredictable and can land on your protected evenings, so you need a real precedent, not a policy line, showing that fixed commitments are actually honored.
- **Treat Design Sprint Facilitator as a freelance business, not a job.** The coach was blunt that “ready now” only applies to the sprint-running skill, while the real work is building pipeline, pricing, chasing invoices, and doing your own sales, which you have not done before.
- **Assume year one solo sprint income is thin unless you already have a referral base.** With zero pipeline, the coach estimated only 2-4 sprints in the first 6 months, roughly £10,000-£20,000, and said you would need 6-9 months of expenses saved or a side-build while employed, not a clean jump.
- **Use the research studio as the real bridge, not a consolation prize.** The coach reframed your dream as already craft-complete, with the missing piece being business infrastructure, and suggested a paid pilot now, one part-time consulting retainer, and a studio model with 2-3 repeat clients as the realistic path.

Saved Responses

Saved response 1

Fair, and worth being precise about rather than diplomatic. Your dream job is "documentary producer," which is hands-on: sourcing stories, shooting or directing crews, owning a production from pitch to final cut. Editorial Director is one layer up and sideways: you're shaping the narrative arc across a slate of projects and giving notes to producers, not running a camera or a shoot yourself. It's closer to what a Brand Strategist does with a strategy deck (finding the throughline in messy material) than to physical production craft.

So it's not a consolation prize, but it's also not the thing itself. It's the version of the documentary world built entirely around the skill you've already proven for 15 years (turning raw material into a story that lands), while skipping the technical production skills you'd have to learn from scratch to actually produce. If the appeal of "documentary producer" is being in the room shaping the story, this gets you most of that. If part of the appeal is learning production craft itself, this quietly sidesteps that.

On the museum salary line: you read it right, that's doing real work in that sentence. Heritage sector pay often clusters well below your £50-75k bracket even at manager level outside national institutions, so it's worth treating as a genuine trade-off against your mortgage, not a footnote.

Saved response 2

That's the part worth sitting with for a second, Emma. The report didn't rate the dream feasible because it's safe, it rated it "Low-Moderate" because the craft fit is genuinely strong and the honest cost is the entry path, not the skill. Nobody handed you permission before because most career advice defaults to "be realistic" as code for "pick smaller." This just showed you the actual mechanism: Executive Producer isn't a consolation prize, it's the same judgment call you've been making for 15 years, aimed at a different kind of material.

And the research studio landing as more feasible isn't a demotion either. It's the same signal from two different angles: your skillset already exists, fully formed, in your current 30+ interviews a year. One dream needs you to build new craft from zero. The other needs you to build a business around craft you already have. That's not a smaller ambition, that's just a shorter distance.

Worth sitting with rather than resolving right now. Whenever you're ready, click "All done, wrap up session" to close out and get your summary.

Also flagged by you

Head of Marketing decision is due by the end of the quarter. Two evenings a week at home by six is a condition, not a preference

THAT IS THE REPORT

You know where you stand.

Revisit this report whenever you need to. You can also share it with mentors, a career advisor, or anyone else who can support your next steps.

ALSO ON YOUR ACCOUNT

Three tools, and your money back

Your assessment comes with a toolkit that opens up as you invite people. Every friend who joins gets 25% off, and each one you bring advances you one step:

-  **Find Job Openings** 1 friend
Search live job openings matched to your top career recommendations.
-  **Tailor Your Resume** 2 friends
Rewrite your uploaded resume to fit the specific jobs you want to apply for.
-  **Tailor Cover Letters** 3 friends
Generate a tailored cover letter for each role, written to the specific posting.
-  **25% refund** 4 friends
Get a quarter of what you paid back to your card.
-  **Additional 25% refund** 5 friends
Another quarter back — now half your purchase recovered.
-  **Remaining 50% refund** 6 friends
The final half back. Your assessment is now completely free.

Six friends and the assessment has cost you nothing. Refunds go back to the card you paid with.

Everything lives on your dashboard at cairnly.io/dashboard